▶ UTTAR PRADESH

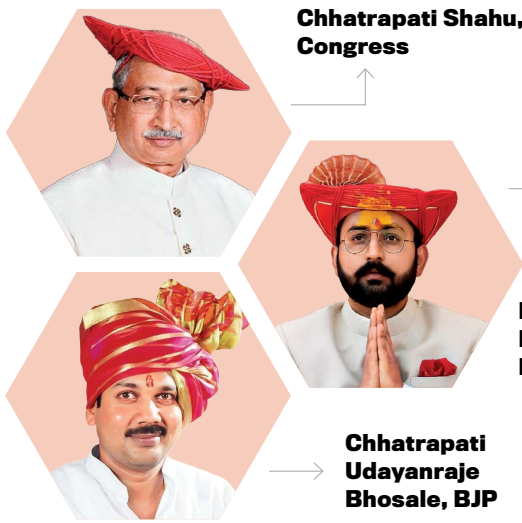
Yadava Dynasty



Akhilesh Yadav likes making up his mind so much that he keeps doing it. Either that, or he's genuinely tentative for some reason—he has changed candidates at the last minute on at least a dozen seats till now. Not surprising, with so much at stake. His own candidature from old party bastion Kannauj, which his wife **Dimple Yadav** had lost by a slender margin in 2019, came as an afterthought. The Samajwadi Party had originally named **Tej Pratap Singh Yadav**—Mulayam's grand-nephew and Lalu Yadav's son-in-law—but Akhilesh succumbed to pressure from party cadre in Kannauj to contest himself. Not a bad way to go. He has had a robust outreach going in the constituency, particularly over the past two years, calling Kannauj "my home" and proclaiming love for its people. Don't discount the chances of a ripple effect either. With his entry, the total number of Yadav family members contesting this Lok Sabha election rises to five: count Dimple (Mainpuri), Ram Gopal Yadav's son and ex-Firozabad MP **Akshay Yadav** (Firozabad), Shivpal Yadav's son **Aditya** (Badaun), and another cousin in **Dharmendra Yadav** (Azamgarh).

▶ MAHARASHTRA

THE MARATHA WARS



Chhatrapati Shahu, Congress

Bhushansinh Raje Holkar, NCP (SCP)

Chhatrapati Udayanraje Bhosale, BJP

Blue-blooded Maharashtra takes its ex-royalty seriously. And why not, when the tales of intrigue today could rival anything from the heyday of the Maratha confederacy. Already, two descendants of the legendary Shivaji–**Chhatrapati Shahu** of Kolhapur and **Chhatrapati Udayanraje Bhosale** of Satara–are in the fray for the Congress and BJP respectively. Now, the wily Sharad Pawar has upped the Maratha sheen of his rump NCP by bringing in **Bhushansinh Raje Holkar**, of the Indore line. The suave architect has been coronated as party veep. He'll be a magnet for the increasingly assertive Dhangar (shepherd) community, from whom the Holkars had descended.

Jumana Shah, Arkamoy Datta Majumdar, Dhaval S. Kulkarni, Rahul Noronha and Prashant Srivastava